freedom that India deserved. Together, these teachers helped transform the minds of a generation of young men—students who had abandoned their studies at government-sponsored schools and colleges in order to flock to an institution which encouraged discussion and dissent. Here the study of history, economics and politics enabled them to learn about the liberation movements of other countries. It was not just that ‘debates had been made a regular feature from the beginning’ of the teaching curriculum, in the words of a former chief secretary of the Delhi Administration, but that here although teaching was in Hindi, ‘students were also taught English’ because many ‘books were only available in English’. History in particular ‘gripped the atmosphere of the college and was the main subject of discussion’.[1] The National College could not escape but be ‘a nursery of revolutionary nationalists’. When undeniably five student members of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association turned out to have betrayed Bhagat Singh in the Lahore Conspiracy Case by becoming ‘Approvers’ for the government, it was a matter of pride for Durga Bhabhi—the rare woman revolutionary in India’s armed freedom struggle, who had helped Bhagat Singh escape in the thick of night by disguising herself as his wife after the shooting of J.P. Saunders—that ‘none of the five had ever been a student of the National College.’[2]

Three teachers in particular stood out at Lahore’s National Law College. There was Bhai Parmanand. Born in 1874, he lived till 1947. He was an Arya Samajist, who had studied history abroad at King’s College London. Tim Murphy reminds us how ‘[l]ike many exiles of all nations, he found sanctuary in the reading room of the British Library’ where he wrote a master’s thesis on ‘The Rise of British Power in India’, but which ‘[h]is examiners did not take to’. In the event, it mattered little to Parmanand who, ‘in any case, . . .had come to the view that English education was introduced to “destroy our national consciousness.’”[3] Parmanand had met with Ghadarites when he was sent abroad in 1912 to preach its doctrines. He was such a thorn in the side of the British that his book on the history of India had been proscribed by the British. James Campbell Ker, who was the personal assistant to the director of criminal intelligence from 1907 to 1913